

The Price of Ageing Gracefully

CC0001 Assignment 1

I plant my palms against the cold iron doors and heave; an icy draft sweeps past my face and seeps into my bones. The shock widens my eyes, exposing what lay beyond: stale air, compartmentalised cubicles, and the dim flickering fluorescent lights.

Hall 9 used to be an exhibition floor, now hollow partition walls draped in dull blue and pink cuts it into numbered cubicles, beds lining it entirely. Every bed has the same adjustable table, the same white towels in the same wardrobe, the same grey cotton shirts and navy scrub pants draping every resident. No windows. Nothing to tell you what hour it is.

The smell hits right after. Isopropyl alcohol and disinfectant, sharp enough to sting, and beneath it, a staler “old people smell”. Closer to the bedsides the abhorrent blend unravels: ammonia, urine, and defecation. It saturates the air, pierces my N95, and lingers in my sinuses for the rest of the hours.

“*KNN CCB!*”¹ tears through the hall. “*I WANT TO GO HOME! WO YAO HUI JIA! FANG WO CHU QU!*”² Hokkien, Mandarin, and English expletives, incessant, broken only by 10-20 seconds of fragile peace before the next shriek shatters it. Most of the staff wear back braces. At bed 184, 8 of us struggle to pin him down as he fights his restraints, and somehow a stray foot still finds my groin.

What stands out, is not that the work is physically exhausting, but mentally, and psychologically. There is no assailant – bed 184 has dementia and schizophrenia, he cannot be held accountable. It is not any single event, but the gradual accumulation: the artificial environment, the smell, the shouting, the physical injuries, the back pain and fatigue that has long term repercussions on one’s health. But nothing can generate a report, a claim, or a case, and is instead absorbed by the frontliners who stand the closest to the problem.

This already has a name. We call this work a calling, and it converts an institutional cost into a private virtue. The burden is shifted onto the workers, and to places the public cannot see. The government paints a beautiful picture of graceful ageing, while covering up the true expense the notion is built on. Virtue is difficult to walk away from; quitting a career is ordinary, but quitting a calling deems you a failure. So, the more devoted the workers are in this sector, the cheaper the promise becomes to keep, with fewer people left to notice the real sacrifice borne by the frontliners.

If vocation is what allows this harm to go uncounted, what does Singapore’s promise of “ageing gracefully” cost, and who has been quietly conscripted to pay it?

450 words (500 words including footnotes)

¹ *KNN CCB!* refers to a hokkien vulgarity, which is not appropriate to be translated in meaning here, but it is used only in some cases, often in anger.

² *WO YAO HUI JIA! FANG WO CHU QU!* can be translated into roughly as, I want to go home! Let me out!